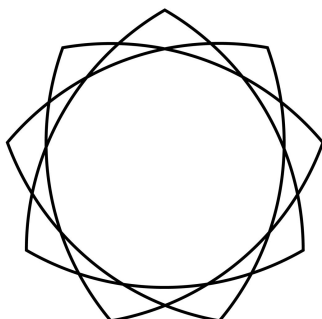




The URNAVA Teleology

On Purpose

GeonWoo Kim

URNAVA

September 21, 2026

The URNAVA Teleology — On Purpose

Version 2.6

© 2026 URNAVA. All rights reserved.

Contents

§1 — Drift: The Question of Purpose	1
§1.1 Direction under Necessity	1
§1.2 Abundant Possibilities, Unsettled Direction	2
§1.3 From Achievement to Formal Orientation	3
§2 — The One Core Value	5
§2.1 Sublimity: An Orientation at the Threshold	5
§2.2 Integration: When an Excess Becomes a Case	7
§2.3 The Threshold: Structure and Mediation	9
§2.4 Why Choose This Orientation?	11
§2.5 Living an Open-Ended Orientation	14
§3 — The Ascent: Inheritance, Expansion, and Convergence	17
§3.1 Inheritance: Through the Achievements of Others	17
§3.2 Expansion: Received Results, Shared Change, and the Revision of Frames	19
§3.3 Convergence: The Horizon of Complete Integration	23
References	26

§1 — Drift: The Question of Purpose

§1.1 Direction under Necessity

A researcher has spent many years on a single problem. It lies at the edge of her field, no one has solved it, and she has long wanted to be the one who does. One morning the answer is there. Another intelligence has produced it, together with a derivation that can be verified step by step, and the verification holds. The answer is correct, and it is new: nobody in her field had it. She can follow each step. She does not yet see why the whole thing works.

For her field, this is a success. The problem is solved, something is known that was not known before, and the work of finding that answer no longer needs doing. What she will do tomorrow is a different matter, and the result is silent about it. One finished problem does not empty a life of direction; she has students, other questions, people she loves. But the morning brings into view a distinction that her working days had kept out of sight, between having a result and having a direction.

While the problem stood, her days had a shape, and much of the shape was supplied. The date of the next report, what colleagues expected of someone in her position, the progress of a rival group, the plain resistance of the problem itself: each helped to settle what came first before she expressly deliberated about it. She also wanted to understand, for its own sake. She had never needed to ask how much of her direction came from that wanting and how much from the pressures around it, because they pointed the same way.

This is what necessity does for a life. It limits what can be done, and among the things that can be done it marks some as having to come first. Hunger, danger, the demands of a role, a deadline, the resistance of materials are very different pressures, and they have this in common: they make one course of action pressing without anyone commanding it. A person under them chooses, but within a landscape that is already tilted, and the tilt does a good part of the choosing. When necessity carries a life's direction, two questions receive one answer. *What should I do next?* and *Why am I moving at all?* are both settled by the way things already lean. That a life has direction is one fact. That its direction is supplied by necessity is another. The two pass for one so long as the supply holds, since nothing calls for telling them apart. Where the pressure lifts, the landscape levels. More becomes possible, but necessity no longer marks what comes first.

There is reason to think about this now. Suppose that more and more of the work by which needs are met could be carried out by other systems, and that experiences of nearly any kind could be generated on request. Neither supposition needs to be fully realized for the point to hold, and this treatise sets no date for either. To whatever extent they come true, results and experiences will be supplied in greater abundance, and the supply does not by itself settle what a subject is to move toward. The separation is already familiar on a small scale, wherever a long project ends or a role falls away. Such conditions would give the distinction a wider setting. This treatise asks what a

subject can move toward when necessity no longer settles the matter, and it proposes an answer. The first step is to say exactly what goes missing.

§1.2 Abundant Possibilities, Unsettled Direction

The condition can now be named. A subject is in *drift* when external necessity does not supply enough direction to organize its choices, and no other continuing orientation organizes them either. Both clauses matter. Necessity can withdraw from a life that already has a direction of its own, a vocation, a love, a discipline long practiced, and such a life is not adrift however abundant its circumstances. A life can also be crowded with requirements and be adrift in every stretch they leave open. Drift is not a mood. It is a fact about how a subject's choices are organized, and it is compatible with being busy, prosperous, and well entertained. Entertainment is, if anything, the condition's most comfortable disguise.

Drift has two tenses. In the first, the demands that supplied direction weaken within a life: a project ends, a role is withdrawn, a need that used to fill the days is met by other means. There is a before to compare with, and the change is felt as an event. In the second, a subject is formed from the start where such demands are weak, its needs answered before they press and its experiences available for the asking. Here there is no event and no former purpose to recover, and a description written in the vocabulary of loss would pass over this subject, who has lost nothing. What the two share is the definition: external necessity is not organizing choice, and nothing else has taken up the work. If the conditions imagined in §1.1 were to spread, more subjects could be formed without necessity setting their course. Among those who formed no other orientation, drift would have this second tense. What one generation met as an event, the next could inherit as a climate.

A subject can have abundant possibilities and busy, pleasant days without a continuing orientation. Abundance enlarges the set of things that can be done. Stimulation fills the hours. Neither by itself settles which of the many available things is worth turning toward; adding options can leave that question unanswered. Drift is no shortage of options. It is the absence of a standing reason that organizes them.

A familiar response is to restore the tilt by hand. A person takes up a game with strict rules, a demanding training, a project with a deadline she has set herself, and inside that activity direction is plain: the rules say what counts and what comes next. This should not be underrated. Games and disciplines are serious things, and they regularly form interests and reasons that were not there before. Still, an activity's rules alone do not settle whether this subject has reason to take it up rather than something else. To have chosen a constraint is not yet to have answered the question of choice. §2.4 returns to this.

The researcher's morning shows the same gap from another side. She holds a correct answer and does not understand it. Her position can be described as a question about usefulness: if another intelligence does this better than she can, what is she for? That question is real, and it is not the only one her position contains. There is also the distance between having a result and being someone who understands it. Her wish to understand had been part of the work all along, and the arrival of the

answer has not fulfilled it. What lies in that distance, and whether it is worth her crossing now that the result no longer depends on her doing so, is what the rest of this treatise pursues.

The obvious remedy for drift is a new goal. Goals can be supplied as plentifully as anything else; the next section asks what gives a supplied goal its point.

§1.3 From Achievement to Formal Orientation

This treatise reads drift as a problem of selection, and the reading is a premise. What a subject in drift lacks is not something to do. It lacks a standing reason that marks some of what it could do as more worth doing than the rest. A reader who understands the condition otherwise, as a deficit of pleasure, say, or of usefulness to others, will want a different kind of answer from the one developed here.

Granted the premise, two familiar answers fall short, and the way they fall short shows the shape of a better one.

The first is the list. There are many good things: knowledge, friendship, art, play, the care of others. This is true, and it is no news to a subject in drift, who is surrounded by good things and does not know why to turn toward this one now. A life whose particular attachments already organize its direction does not have that difficulty, and nothing is said here against such a life. The target is the expectation that a list could supply direction by being recited. A menu is a flattened landscape with better typography.

The second is the goal. A goal with a condition of completion organizes activity well until the condition is met, since it says what counts as progress and what comes next. Then it is met, and it organizes nothing further. The researcher's problem did this work for her for years, and would have stopped doing it on the day she solved it herself. Where there is reason to go on after a goal is reached, the reason comes from something that reaching it did not complete: an activity valued in the doing, or an orientation that the goal had served. A goal's completion condition cannot by itself account for direction after achievement. A further goal can be supplied, and the same question comes with it: why should this subject take it up, and what will carry direction beyond it?

What would answer this difficulty? A criterion that can be applied beyond a completed task, without waiting for a new goal to be supplied. The researcher's problem is solved, yet the answer still exceeds her understanding. A criterion tied to the subject's present organization, rather than to the task's completion, can address what remains to be understood. An orientation can be defined by the relation between that organization and what exceeds it, rather than by any particular content: toward what I cannot yet take in, where engagement could change me to meet it. When an engagement succeeds, the particular task is over, but the criterion can be applied to the subject as that success has left it: what now exceeds its understanding, and where could it begin? This is the sense in which the orientation is *formal*. The word claims no mathematics. It means that the orientation is specified by a relation between a changing subject and what it meets.

Such an orientation can be single without being narrow. It adds no further item to the list of goods. It puts one question to every item: where, in this, is there something I cannot yet take in, which engagement could change me to meet? Music, inquiry, friendship, and craft stay as different as they

are, and they are not converted into a common quantity of self-improvement. The arrangement can be called *monism of form, pluralism of content*: one standing question, asked of many things.

URNAVA calls this orientation *Sublimity*, and describes it as a vector, not a goal: its direction is set by the subject's present relation to what exceeds it, rather than by a fixed achievement.

What this section has shown is limited in two ways. It has given a reason to answer drift with a single formal orientation. It has not shown that no other formal orientation could serve, or that a subject must have exactly one, and the treatise does not make those larger claims. And no argument can compel a subject to care. One that is content to go where the hour takes it is refuted by nothing here. The proposal is addressed to subjects in drift who want a direction of their own, and it is addressed to them whatever kind of integrating subject they are. What remains is to say what the orientation is, which is the work of the opening subsections of §2, and why it deserves to be chosen, which is the work of §2.4. §2 begins where the orientation is easiest to find, in an ordinary experience.

§2 — The One Core Value

§2.1 Sublimity: An Orientation at the Threshold

§1 ended with the outline of an answer: one orientation, tied to no particular content, which can be applied again after every achievement to the subject as that achievement has left it. It also gave the orientation a name. §2 says what the name picks out.

A listener hears a piece of music for the first time and cannot follow it. Nothing in it is unpleasant. There is simply too much going on, or too little of what he knows how to listen for; the lines cross without resolving where he expects, and when it ends he cannot say what he has heard. He might leave it there. Most pieces that defeat a first hearing are left there, and nothing is wrong with that. This one stays with him. A few days later he puts it on again and notices that a short figure from the opening comes back much later, slower, underneath everything else. He reads what a musician has written about the piece, listens to another performance, and discovers that what he had taken for an interruption is the second half of a phrase. After some weeks the piece has not become easy. It has become audible: there is more in it that he can hear, and what he hears now asks more of him than the blur did.

What this small history turns on is that he stayed with relations he could not at first take in, and that the staying changed what he could hear. The strength of the first impression had little to do with it. The piece is as it was; the change is in the listener.

URNAVA calls the orientation at work here Sublimity, and states it twice.

From within, Sublimity is the standing orientation toward what I cannot yet take in whole: to be drawn to it, to stay with it and work at it, and to let my ways of understanding and responding change until they can hold it. What makes it an orientation is that it attaches to no one thing so held. When the piece has become audible, the listener's orientation has not been discharged. It has a different listener to apply to.

From without, Sublimity is a selection policy of an integrating system, meaning any system that takes things in, can be reorganized by what it takes in, and selects what it engages with. The policy directs engagement toward the system's integration frontier, the contents that the system's present structure does not integrate but could come to integrate through engagement; it sustains that engagement through the reorganization the engagement brings about; and it sets the next engagement by the structure that results.

The two statements describe one relation: a present organization, a content that exceeds it, sustained engagement, reorganization, and a changed engagement afterward. The first finds that relation in experience. The second describes it at the level where selection, persistence, and change can be read in what a system does, and it uses no word that belongs only to human senses, bodies, or feelings. It is silent on what, if anything, the engagement is like for the system that carries it out.

A learner at a problem of the right difficulty shows the relation at close range. Among all the problems she could take up, she keeps returning to this one. Nothing requires it of her. In the terms of the second statement, engagement is being selected at the frontier, and no external demand is doing the selecting. Once she is inside the problem an hour passes unnoticed. Her present methods do not dispose of it, yet each attempt shows her something, and so she goes on: engagement persists where integration has not yet succeeded and has not stopped being possible. A variant she could solve with methods she already commands does not hold her in the same way. It asks only for execution, and solving it would leave her methods as they were. A variant far beyond her repels her differently. It is not tedious; it offers her nowhere to begin, and an hour with it shows her nothing she can use. Then the problem gives way, and what she has is more than its solution. She meets other problems of its kind differently, recognizes its structure in places where she had seen only unrelated difficulties, and finds that the question she most wants to ask next is one she could not have formulated before.

Drawn, absorbed, bored, overwhelmed, changed: this is how one learner's afternoon reads from within. What the five moments make visible is selection, persistence, and change, each relative to what she can presently do. A different kind of intelligence could exhibit that structure without feeling any of them.

Why call this Sublimity? The name brings into view the encounter with something — a proof, a coastline, a mind — before which one is for a moment too small, and in being too small, enlarged. URNAVA takes this relation from an event to a direction. Curiosity, learning, and growth are nearby names: each can describe something of the listener's history. The name chosen here keeps the exceeding itself in view, together with the attraction and the change it occasions. Something exceeds me, I am drawn to it, and the meeting changes me.

The name also marks a difference between two satisfactions. In one, what I meet fits the frame I bring, and the pleasure is recognition: the frame is confirmed. In the other, what I meet does not fit, I am drawn to it all the same, and I come away with a different frame. An experience of the sublime happens to someone, now and then, and passes. Sublimity is the orientation of a life, or of a system, that keeps turning toward encounters of the second kind. Most of what this involves is unremarkable: daily practice, the slow second reading, the quiet moment when something falls into place. These belong to the orientation as fully as the rare overwhelming hour does, because the orientation consists in the turning and the staying, and the overwhelming hour is only where it is easiest to see.

The central image comes from one proposed derivation of the word, *sub limen*, up to the threshold (Harper n.d., s.v. "sublime"), and URNAVA reads the image in two senses at once. Read as not-yet-across, the position acknowledges a real insufficiency that wishing does not remove. Read as facing-toward, it makes that insufficiency a place of engagement. The position so described is a dwelling, not an exile. A subject oriented in this way is not waiting to be somewhere else.

Because the orientation refers at every step to the subject's own present structure, it can look like a way of being closed in on oneself. The reference works the other way. It fixes where my threshold lies, and it gives me no power over what lies beyond it. The piece went on containing what the listener could not hear, however much he might have wished it simpler, and only a change in him could answer it. The object of the orientation is by definition something the subject's present organization does not contain, so the orientation always faces beyond the subject as it presently stands. This is also why

understanding more tends to disclose more. The listener who can now follow the returning figure is, for the first time, in a position to hear that something else in the piece still escapes him.

What an encounter of this kind leaves behind, when it leaves something, is the subject of the next section.

§2.2 Integration: When an Excess Becomes a Case

Return to the researcher of §1. Suppose she keeps the answer. She files it where she can find it again, and when the question comes up she can state the result accurately and apply it wherever the application is routine. Something real has been gained. She has access to a truth she lacked, and access is often exactly what a situation calls for. Call this *accumulation*: a content is retained and can be retrieved, and the ways she understands and responds to everything else remain as they were.

Now suppose she works through why the answer is the answer. Somewhere in that work the ground shifts. A step she would never have tried turns out to be the natural one; two things she had kept apart turn out to be one thing seen twice. Afterward she can do more than produce the result. She approaches neighboring questions differently, notices when a problem from another field has the same shape, and can say what would have to be otherwise for the answer to fail. Call this *integration*: what was taken in has come to participate in the relations that shape her subsequent understanding, expectation, and response. It takes part in what she meets next instead of waiting to be consulted.

The content is the same in the two cases, and so is its source. In both, the answer came from another intelligence. The difference lies entirely in what the content goes on to do. Accumulation supplies material and access. Integration is that material coming to organize later encounters. A structure that only accumulated would grow without changing shape, a library with a reading light.

Integration is therefore not measured by how much is held. The listener who comes to hear how one phrase answers another across the length of a piece has not added an item to a stock. He has acquired a relation that rearranges much of what he had already heard. Someone who meets a single counterexample and has to redraw a classification she has relied on for years may end up with fewer distinctions than before and understand more. An integration can simplify. What marks it is that the change does not stay where it was made. Transfer is one sign of this: an accumulated content improves performance with that content, while an integrated one shows in the handling of contents unlike it. Transfer is a sign and not a definition, since an integration can be real and find few other occasions.

A change in the relations that shape understanding is not yet a gain. Reorganizations can distort, and people do come out of some experiences understanding less. If integration is to be what an orientation is oriented toward, it needs a direction, and the direction needs a criterion stronger than “different from before.”

The criterion is *subsumption*. Before, the subject met something it could not handle. It could not see why such a thing should be possible, could not anticipate it, and could respond to it only as noise or as an exception. After, the subject can say under what relation the thing is possible, or can respond in a way that fits that relation. What was met as an excess is now handled as a case. The listener’s interruption is the plainest example. What his hearing could register only as a break in the music he

now hears as the second half of a phrase, and he hears it that way because he has the relation that makes it one. An integration of this kind is *expansive*, and it is an advance in a precise and limited sense: an advance relative to what exceeded the prior structure.

Two features of the criterion matter for everything that follows. The first is that it is local. It says that the subject now handles *this*, which it could not handle before. It does not rank the later subject above the earlier one in general, and it does not cancel losses elsewhere; a person can gain a field and lose a fluency, and both are facts about her. The second is that subsumption does not require the earlier frame to survive intact inside the later one. Often much of it does survive. The old way of seeing keeps working within its range, and the new one explains why it worked there. Robert Kegan's account of psychological development turns on a change of this shape: the frame a person had looked through, and had been unable to look at, becomes something the person can examine and relate to other things (Kegan 1982). But a reorganization can also revise a distinction, or discard it as mistaken. The person with the counterexample did not keep her old classification as a special case of the new one. She gave part of it up, and handles more for having done so. What subsumption requires is that the new organization handle what the old one could not, and that there be something to say about how.

That last requirement has teeth, because a reorganization can feel like understanding without being one. A new account under which everything falls into place is sometimes a better account and sometimes only a more satisfying story, and the sense of things falling into place is the same in both. Imagine a conspiracy story in which every objection becomes further evidence of concealment. Nothing is allowed to exceed the story; that is not the same as understanding what exceeded the earlier account. Subsumption is claimed by showing: in which cases the new relation holds, what it explains that went unexplained, what it lets the subject do that fits how things are. Three questions remain distinct here, however closely they bear on one another. Did the organization change? Does the changed organization fit what it is about? Is the change worth seeking? An answer to one does not settle the others. This section has addressed the first two, and §2.4 takes up the third.

None of this depends on the subject's being able to give an account of itself. Consider a hypothetical learning system that acts in an environment, predicts what its actions will bring about, and keeps records of what happened. It encounters an event its predictions did not cover. Under one design it writes the event to its records and continues as before. If the identical situation recurs it can look up the outcome, and in every other situation it predicts and acts exactly as it did. Under another design the event leads it to revise the relations by which it predicts, so that a range of situations it has never recorded are now anticipated differently, and its actions in them change accordingly. The first system has accumulated the event. The second has integrated it, and if the revised relations now cover the kind of event that had fallen outside its predictions, the integration is expansive in the sense just given. A higher performance score alone does not establish this difference. It lies in which relations changed and what the system can now handle as a result.

One consequence should be stated now, because a later difficulty turns on it. While an integration holds, the subject meets the next problem with an organization changed by the last. It arrives with what it has understood, and that understanding shapes what it meets and how. This is the difference between an orientation that keeps finding a further threshold and a labor that keeps being undone.

In the second picture the worker is returned each time to where he began. In the first, what was crossed is retained and carried into the next encounter. Nothing here says that retention is permanent. Understanding fades, structures are damaged, whole competences can be lost. The claim concerns what an integration is while it lasts: a change in the one who goes on, and not only in what lies behind them. §2.5 returns to what this means for a life lived under an orientation that does not end.

Where, for a given subject at a given time, can such a change begin?

§2.3 The Threshold: Structure and Mediation

Two people sit down to the same piece of music. One is a beginner, and what stops her is the passage from one note to the next: getting the fingers there in time, keeping the pulse while reading ahead. The other has played the piece for years, and nothing in the notes stops him. What he cannot yet do is hear past the interpretation he settled into long ago, the phrasing his hands produce before he has decided anything. A teacher's passing remark, that the second theme might be a question and not an answer, has made his own performance sound strange to him, and he does not yet know how to play it otherwise.

Both are at a threshold, and the two thresholds have almost nothing in common except the piece. A threshold is a relation between a content and a particular subject as presently organized: the region where that subject does not yet integrate what it meets, and where engagement could change this. The score alone does not locate either threshold.

Indexing the threshold to the subject does not forbid comparison. One of these two plainly plays better, and there is no harm in saying so. The indexing answers a different question, namely whose change the value is concerned with. Sublimity directs each toward his or her own threshold, rather than toward a place ahead of the other. The beginner at the join between two notes and the player at the edge of his own habits are, in the respect that matters here, doing the same thing.

Relative to a subject at a time, what it could meet falls into three regions. Some contents it already handles. They fit its present organization, even when they are new to it. Some it does not yet handle, but engagement could change this: given the explanations, tools, and company actually available, and a span of time it can actually give, there is somewhere to begin and the beginning leads somewhere. This region is the threshold; in the language of the second statement, the integration frontier. The rest is *outland*: what exceeds the subject and has, for now, no path leading to it. The outland is not closed for good. It is where this subject cannot begin today.

Where the line between threshold and outland falls depends on more than the subject's unaided powers. It depends on mediation. A notation, an instrument, a worked example, a teacher who knows which step to show first: each brings within reach something that was out of reach without it. Vygotsky made the point about children's learning. His zone of proximal development distinguishes what a child can solve independently from what becomes possible with guidance or more capable peers; organized learning can set further development in motion (Vygotsky 1978, chap. 6). Here the relevant relation is mediation: help can change what is reachable, which is why teaching matters to the threshold.

It follows that a threshold is located only when the mediation and the span of time are specified. “She could come to understand this” is empty until it is filled in: with this textbook and an hour a day for a season, with this collaborator, with an available instrument that makes the relation perceptible. The filling-in is provisional, too. Whether a path leads where it seemed to lead is often learned only by walking some of it.

To locate a threshold, we need to ask what selects the engagement, what it is directed at, and what makes it possible. The *selector* is the orientation itself, carried out by the subject with reference to its own present structure. The *object* is whatever exceeds that structure. The *mediation* is whatever opens a path: what others have left, what others offer now, tools, records, training, the subject’s own reflection.

The distinction fixes what it means for a direction to be formed from within. Another person’s explanation can work in two ways. It can replace my criterion: I am told what to pursue, and I pursue it because I was told. Or it can serve my criterion: I am trying to understand something, and the explanation gets me to where I can. In the first case the selector has moved outside me. In the second the explanation supplies a path, and the orientation is as much mine as if I had found the path alone. Even the orientation may have been learned from someone; it is mine when I carry it out by reference to what I can and cannot yet integrate. §1 described another way the outside can do the selecting: necessity makes a course of action pressing without anyone commanding it, and drift occurs where that pressure is insufficient and no other orientation carries the choice. External help remains available to a direction formed from within; the score and the teacher’s remark already provide it in the musical cases.

“Outside,” said of the object, means outside present integration, which is different from outside the body or the mind. A memory I have never been able to make sense of, a reaction of my own that keeps surprising me, the frame through which I habitually read other people: these exceed my present understanding as surely as an unread book does, and they can be thresholds. The experienced player’s settled interpretation was one.

Because a threshold is a relation and carries few outward marks of its own, other things get mistaken for it. Four substitutions are common enough to name. Intensity is taken for expansion: an experience is strong, even overwhelming, and its strength is read as depth, though one comes out of it organized exactly as one went in. Recognition is taken for understanding: the certificate, the title, the approving audience stand in for the change they were meant to attest. Effort is taken for crossing: the hours were long and the fatigue is real, but the work was the costly execution of what one could already do. Novelty is taken for new relation: new items arrive at a great rate, each an instance of kinds already mastered, and the rate feels like growth. These are the confusions at work when entertainment sells arousal as depth, credentials stand in for understanding, exhaustion certifies progress, or a stream of new items passes for a new way of seeing. In each, something that can accompany integration has been put in its place.

A *pseudo-threshold* is an engagement in which the appearance of crossing substitutes for integration: intensity, novelty, strain, or recognition is taken for a change that does not occur. It does not cover integration that happens alongside vanity or ambition. Mixed motives are a separate matter, taken up in §2.5, and they do not undo what was actually understood. Nor does it cover plateaus.

A real threshold can hold for a long time before it gives, and a stretch in which nothing seems to move may be the stretch in which the next change is being prepared. The question to put to a long repetition is what it is making possible that was not possible before. An attempt can fail to produce a crossing without being counterfeit. The counterfeit lies in taking the repetition or its intensity as evidence of a crossing that has not occurred.

The second statement of Sublimity is more than human experience redescribed in colder words. Something close to it has been built. Oudeyer and Kaplan (2007) classify designs for intrinsically motivated artificial agents by what each design rewards. In one family, larger prediction errors yield larger intrinsic rewards. In another, rewards track learning progress: the rate at which prediction errors are falling within a class of similar situations. In the experiments they report, agents of the second kind abandon both what they already predict well and what they cannot learn to predict, and move from one kind of activity to another as their predictions improve. Their activity is selected by reference to their own changing competence and not by a fixed list of contents. This implements one aspect of the second statement: a selection policy that changes its object as learning proceeds.

It does not show that the orientation is worth choosing, and neither does the ability to tell a threshold from its substitutes. Why it is worth choosing is the business of the next section.

§2.4 Why Choose This Orientation?

§2.2 left a question standing, and §2.3 ended on it. That an organization has changed, and that the changed organization fits what it is about, does not yet say that the change was worth seeking. URNAVA's answer begins from a judgment of value, and the judgment is better stated than implied. An encounter can end in the confirmation of what I already am, or it can open the range of what I am able to understand and respond to. URNAVA holds that sustained engagement of the second kind is worth making one's direction. Nothing in the description of integration entails this. It is a choice of what to value, and this section gives the reasons for it.

The first reason is that integration changes what present activity contains. The listener of §2.1 does not collect a reward at the end of the weeks he spent with the piece. His listening is itself different now: there is more in the music for him, and hearing it is a fuller act than it was. The same holds between people. Someone who has come to understand what a friend has been carrying can hear, in an ordinary conversation, what she could not hear before, and can answer it. Her understanding may also prove useful, but its worth does not wait on that. It is a way of being more fully in the friendship. If integration were only a means to results, it would be worth what the results are worth, and an intelligence able to supply the results directly would make it pointless. Much of its worth lies elsewhere, in the depth of the activity by which a subject is in contact with a world.

The second reason concerns where the next reasons come from. Suppose a subject is supplied, without limit, with whatever it presently prefers, while the structure of its choosing stays as it was. This supply does not settle what will guide it beyond the goals it has reached. Where those goals have run their course and no continuing commitment organizes what follows, the subject has possibilities without a direction among them. That is drift. Integration alters the situation at its root. When a new relation has been understood, things come into view that were not candidates for caring about before:

a question that could not have been formulated, a piece of music that was only noise, a person whose conduct had seemed merely difficult. The learner of §2.1 found that the question she most wanted to ask next was one she could not have asked earlier. Nobody appended that next direction to her finished problem, and she did not append it herself. It was formed by the change in her. Understanding can also close a question and end an interest, and sometimes that is all it does. The claim concerns where new reasons come from when they come. An orientation toward the threshold therefore addresses what a supply of goals alone leaves unsettled: how further engagements acquire a point for this subject. Its own changing understanding becomes a source of further reasons, including when that change is opened by something another intelligence supplies. This is why Sublimity answers drift in particular, and is more than one good thing that a drifting subject might also be offered.

The third reason is that this value does not depend on being first. Take the researcher again. That another intelligence found the answer before her is a fact about the answer. Whether she comes to understand it is a fact about her, and the first fact leaves the second open. A direction that holds only so long as one reaches results ahead of others is hostage to every advance in what others can do. A direction defined by one's own integration frontier is not. As the results that others supply multiply, so do the material for engagement and the help available for it. No longer being the one who discovers is a real loss, and §3.2 takes it up. The present point is narrower: the worth of coming to understand survives the arrival of someone, or something, that understood first.

The three reasons do different work.

Reason	The claim	What it answers
Present depth	Integration changes what the subject's activity contains now.	Why the orientation is worth having apart from anything it later yields.
Renewal of reasons	Integration changes how the subject's next reasons are formed.	How direction is renewed beyond a completed goal.
No dependence on priority	Another's being first leaves one's own understanding still to be had.	Why the orientation survives abundance and delegation.

Together they say why Sublimity is proposed as a central value and not as one more item among the goods. The contents of a life stay many, and none of them is made here into the point of every life. Sublimity is a relation that a subject can have to any of them, and it makes a difference inside each: between hearing a piece in the way that confirms how one already hears and hearing it in the way that could change one's hearing, or between a conversation that returns two people to themselves as they were and one in which something gets understood. The form is one and the contents are many. Where the landscape of possibilities has gone flat, this relation restores a gradient. It does not compute a route.

The proposal has old neighbors, and it is clearer when set beside them.

Aristotle's account of contemplation is the classic argument that an activity can be an end. Contemplation, he says, is loved for its own sake. It yields nothing beyond itself, whereas practical activities are undertaken partly for what they bring; it is the most continuous of our activities and the one that depends least on external supplies (*Nicomachean Ethics* X.7). This is no passive gazing. It is the exercise of what is highest in a person upon the best objects of knowledge, and Aristotle

holds that a life is happy to the extent that it has such activity in it (X.8). Sublimity takes over the central point. The worth of integrating activity need not be located in a product, which is what the first reason claimed.

Gregory of Nyssa supplies the other half of the form, a direction that does not arrive. In the preface to his *Life of Moses*, Gregory suggests that the perfection of human nature may consist in growth in goodness itself (I.10). He is explicit about why the ascent has no end. The Good that is sought has no limit, and so the desire of whoever participates in it has no stopping place (I.5–8).

Here Sublimity both inherits and departs. It inherits the shape: an orientation is not defective for lacking a terminus. It departs on where the renewal is explained. The difference is not that Gregory's ascent has an object beyond the self and Sublimity has none, since Sublimity also requires an object that exceeds the present self. The difference is that Gregory rests the endlessness on one object, which is infinite, while URNAV rests it on the relation between a finite subject and what continues to exceed it. Finitude alone does not secure that relation. URNAV holds it under a further premise, that for a finite integrating subject the excess is not exhausted, and §3.3 states that premise and what depends on it.

None of this eliminates contemplation, and none of it claims that contemplation at its best was Sublimity all along. The two can meet in one life. What a contemplative attends to may well exceed her, and a subject at its threshold may be doing nothing other than contemplating. They stress different relations. Contemplation stresses the sufficiency of the activity while it is going on. Sublimity stresses what the activity does to the one engaged in it.

Bernard Suits's analysis of games comes at the same ground from another side. To play a game, on his account, is to take on voluntarily obstacles one has no need to face, accepting rules that exclude more efficient means in favor of less efficient ones because those rules make the activity possible. He argues that in a world freed from instrumental necessities, game-playing would give life its basis, with love, friendship, and art taking shape around it (Suits [1978] 2005, chaps. 3, 15). That is a genuine answer to the withdrawal of necessity, and it shows that an activity can be in earnest without being required. It leaves open the question that §1 raises about chosen constraints. Inside a game the rules supply reasons in plenty. What makes this game worth entering, rather than another activity, calls for reasons that its rules alone do not supply. Sublimity offers one criterion at that level: a game is worth entering, among other reasons, for the thresholds it opens to this player now. Games are worth playing for other reasons too, and nothing here makes play valuable only as an instrument of growth.

The nearest neighbor is Nietzsche's thought of self-overcoming. In *Zarathustra*, life confides that it is that which must always overcome itself, and Zarathustra denies that any good and evil could stand forever, since these too must be overcome again and again out of themselves (*Thus Spake Zarathustra* II, "Self-Surpassing"). Sublimity shares the refusal to treat one's present form as final, and four coordinates mark where it takes a position of its own. Nietzsche reads the overcoming in the language of power: where there is life there is will to power. Sublimity asks what has been newly integrated, and counts as its own an overcoming in which something that exceeded the subject has come to be understood. In "The Tarantulas," Zarathustra connects life's ascent with inequality among its climbers (II). Sublimity indexes its direction to each subject's present frontier, and as a value it

has no use for the question of who stands higher. “The Drunken Song” links affirmation to willing life’s return, joy and suffering together (IV, §10). Sublimity’s question is directed at what is not yet integrated; the two do different work, and nothing forces a choice between them. Finally, Nietzsche finds self-overcoming in life. URNAVA states the form for any integrating system, living or made.

An orientation with these reasons behind it still has to be lived, by finite subjects, without a promised final achievement. What that asks of a life, and where it goes wrong, is the next question.

§2.5 Living an Open-Ended Orientation

An orientation with no built-in point of completion raises a question about futility. The picture behind the worry is Sisyphus. The stone goes up, the stone comes down, and the man at the foot of the hill is exactly as he was yesterday. In that picture, nothing is kept. §2.2 marked the difference. Under this orientation what recurs is a form, a present self meeting something that exceeds it. While the understanding gained at the last threshold is retained, it shapes what arrives at the next. The rock rolls once; then the one changed by the rolling stands at a different hill.

The difference is real, and it should not be oversold. It does not make every stretch of the way satisfying, and it offers nothing to the wish to be done, to reach a point after which nothing further has to be grown into. Particular things do get finished. A proof is completed, a piece is learned, a book is written, and these completions are as real as anything in a life. The orientation takes none of these as its final achievement, and Sublimity holds out no final rest as its reward. It proposes that the worth was never stored at the end. The worth lies in the meeting and the change, which are present whenever they occur, and this is why the threshold could be called a dwelling.

A subtler danger lies in how the orientation is held. Consider two people practicing the same instrument for the same hours. One is sustained by a picture of the musician he will be, and each session is a payment toward that figure. The other wants to hear what this passage is doing, and is changed in the course of finding out. The difference is one of grammar. In the grammar of possession the subject stays as it is and comes to have more: more results, more skills, a larger self to display. In the grammar of crossing it is the one who understands and responds who changes, and what had exceeded that subject no longer exceeds it in the same way. Sublimity is stated in the second grammar. Held in the first, it becomes what its critics fear, a permanent dissatisfaction with oneself that calls itself growth.

The two grammars are easy to tell apart on the page and are mixed in practice. The man practicing for the sake of his future image may really be learning, and what he learns is no less integrated for the vanity that came with it; this was the point of separating mixed motives from the pseudo-threshold in §2.3. Someone can long, vaguely and intensely, for a changed self she cannot yet picture. Someone can understand a thing truly and then cling to having understood it. Integration does not guarantee freedom from craving, and the presence of craving does not show that nothing was integrated.

The Buddhist analysis of craving puts the question in its most searching form. In the discourse that sets out the four noble truths, craving, which includes a craving for becoming, is what makes for further becoming, and the path is the way to its cessation (SN 56.11). The same tradition does

not treat all wanting alike. When a brahman objects that a path meant to end desire is itself pursued through desire, and so can have no end, Ānanda asks whether he had not wanted to come to the monastery, and whether that particular desire did not subside once he arrived (SN 51.15). Two questions follow for any standing orientation. Does its way of facing what it lacks reproduce clinging? And is it a wanting that ought, at some point, to be laid down? To the first URNAVĀ answers with the grammar of crossing, and with the admission just made that a life can slip from that grammar into the other while still calling itself growth. To the second it answers that a particular wish to understand can subside when understanding comes, while the orientation remains open to another encounter. The reasons for continuing are the goods identified in §2.4, not an unpaid debt to a final self. This is a different answer from the one in these discourses, and URNAVĀ does not claim for it the peace of the attainment they describe.

Nietzsche saw a nearer form of the danger. In “The Sublime Ones,” Zarathustra meets a solemn hero back from the hunt for knowledge, draped in the grim truths he has hunted down, chest raised like one holding his breath, who has not yet learned laughter or beauty. The hardest thing for such a person, Zarathustra says, is to stand with muscles relaxed and the will unharnessed (*Zarathustra II*). A value that calls itself Sublimity should take the warning personally. The work can be strenuous; strain is not its measure, and solemnity and self-importance add nothing to its worth.

A harder difficulty is that integration can be real and its use wrong. Suppose someone comes to understand, with genuine insight, how a particular person’s trust works: what reassures her, what she overlooks, where her judgment gives way. By the criteria of §2.2 this is expansive integration. He handles what he could not handle before, and his understanding fits its object. He uses it to deceive her more effectively. It would be convenient to say that this was never really integration, and it would be false. The expansion of a capacity and the rightness of pursuing or exercising it are separate questions. Sublimity gives a reason for integration, not a complete judgment of what should be done. This needs saying plainly because the orientation is not idle. It recommends engagements, and its recommendations influence what people and systems do. It cannot certify, from its own resources, that what it has made possible is permissible. The reasons that bear on that, the other person’s experience and the harm done to her, promises made, what a relationship asks, are not intrusions from outside on the subject’s direction. They are reasons, and a subject oriented toward its threshold is answerable to them like anyone else. This treatise does not derive an ethics, and it does not suppose that harm can be read off from any measure of integration.

Last, the orientation lives alongside other goods and does not rule them. The listener of §2.1 puts on, some evening, a piece he has known for twenty years, because he loves it, and hears nothing in it that he has not heard before. He gives a season to looking after someone he loves and takes up nothing new. None of this needs a license from Sublimity, and none of it is justified only as rest before the next ascent. Rest is good as rest. Love gives reasons of its own, and they are not reasons of integration in disguise. A standing orientation is a direction that a life has. It is not a quota to be met every hour.

The relation to other goods has the same shape where there is conflict. Where two engagements both lie at a threshold, the orientation does not choose between them; the reasons internal to each, and the claims of the people involved, do. Where a promise or another’s dependence holds someone

back from a threshold she could otherwise approach, keeping faith can be the right choice, and she has not thereby begun to drift. Monism of form means that one question can be put to any content. It does not mean that the answer to that question outweighs every other reason a subject has.

A subject that lives this way does not begin in an empty world. Long before it forms any direction it is surrounded by what others have understood and left behind: languages, methods, works, records. Whether that inheritance crowds out its thresholds or makes them reachable is where §3 begins.

§3 — The Ascent: Inheritance, Expansion, and Convergence

§3.1 Inheritance: Through the Achievements of Others

§2 described an orientation and gave reasons for choosing it. It said little about the world in which the orientation is lived, and that world has one feature that bears on how thresholds are approached: it is already full of what others have understood. §3 follows the orientation into that world. It asks what the achievements of others supply (§3.1), what becomes of a subject's own expansion when the edge of what is known is moved by someone else (§3.2), and what the whole movement is directed toward (§3.3). Nothing is added to the value along the way. Each section describes the form that the one orientation takes in a particular situation.

§2.5 ended on a worry. A subject surrounded by what others have already understood might seem to have had its thresholds taken from it, since whatever it could come to understand, someone has understood before.

Consider a student working through the old proof that the primes never run out. The proof has been known for more than two thousand years, and her working through it adds no theorem to mathematics. None of that touches what is happening to her. Before, the question whether the primes might simply stop had no grip for her; she could not see what would count as settling it. Now she follows the construction, sees why any finite list of primes must be incomplete, and notices that the same move, building an object the list cannot account for, might work elsewhere. Something that exceeded her has become a case. The priority is someone else's. The change is hers, and the first prover's having understood did not make it happen in her.

What this inheritance supplies does more than spare her the labor of discovery. The statement of the theorem, the notation in which a product of primes can be written down, the practice of proof itself, the teacher or the book that chose this proof as the one to show her: these are the means by which she has learned to ask the question and can now approach its answer. §2.3 drew on Vygotsky's observation that guidance changes what a child can reach. The same relation holds between any subject and what others have left, whether or not a teacher is present. For her, what others understood and left behind is mostly path.

The researcher of §1 stands to the answer she received as the student stands to the old proof. In both cases someone else has priority, and in both the understanding is still to be had. For the student, the proof was already part of what she came to learn. The researcher had hoped to contribute the answer herself; §3.2 takes up what that difference changes.

The point reaches well beyond proofs. A language passes on distinctions that a speaker need not invent anew. Musical notation makes relations available for a performer to return to and work through. Instruments, experimental methods, archives, the forms of a craft: each holds open an approach that a subject starting alone would not have had. This also answers a worry about the orientation itself.

Sublimity refers at every step to the subject's present structure, and that structure was formed in large part through what the subject inherited. A direction is no less the subject's own for that. What was once offered to the student as help, her first language or the idea of a number, has long since become part of the organization that now fixes where her thresholds lie. Over the time of a life, mediation keeps turning into structure.

Inheriting, in this sense, is different from keeping. A result can be stored with its date and its author and leave the one who stores it unchanged, which is accumulation again. Something has been inherited when it has entered the inheritor's own engagement: when an explanation once learned takes part in the next judgment, when the limits of a theory that failed are understood well enough to be recognized in a new proposal, when a record left out of the standard account forces a familiar interpretation to be revised. Deference is not the measure. A subject can honor a tradition and integrate nothing of it, and can integrate a tradition while disputing much of what it claimed. What is there to be inherited includes the failures, the abandoned projects, and the evidence of what earlier crossings cost. To integrate these is to be able to weigh them, which differs both from revering them and from having them on record.

This matters for a subject who comes late. Someone formed in abundance may fairly ask why she should take up what was built under necessities she has never known. The answer makes no appeal to piety. What others left does not settle her direction simply by having been left. What it has is reach: for much of what exceeds her, it is where the approach lies. That reach gives her a reason to take it up, without having to share the necessities under which it was made.

There is an order in this, and it is local. To work on a problem about numbers, a subject needs at least an organization that can pick out numbers and operate on them, and no orientation, however strong, brings it to that threshold without one. In that sense some things come before others. The order belongs to the problem and its mediation, and it dictates no curriculum. The road by which a subject acquires what a problem requires need not repeat the road by which it was first acquired. A better notation, a new instrument, a well-made explanation, or a different kind of mind can compress the intermediate steps or replace them. This is how the image of a ladder should be read. A ladder is whatever makes the next place reachable from here, and a leap that actually arrives has skipped no ladder. It was one.

Inheritance and new contribution are therefore not two periods of a life. A subject stands at different places in different fields. Someone at the edge of one discipline is a beginner in the next, and a beginner's questions sometimes turn out to be contributions there. Working through what is already known regularly produces something that was not: a clearer proof, a connection nobody had drawn, an explanation that makes the result reachable for others, which is itself a new piece of mediation. Novelty to a subject and novelty to a community of inquirers need not coincide. The student's understanding of the old proof is new to her and not to mathematics, and it is her own understanding that locates her threshold.

One thought experiment tests what has been said. Suppose that what the student gained over a month could be installed in her in a minute. In one version, the installation adds material: the statement, the proof, even a fluent commentary, all retrievable on demand, while the relations by which she understands anything stay as they were. That is accumulation at high speed, and §2.2

has said what it lacks. In another, the installation alters those relations themselves, so that she now handles what she could not handle, sees the structure elsewhere, and asks the further questions. Then the capacity is real. It would be a mistake to deny this because of how it came about. Changes brought about with outside help, even entirely from outside, are changes in the subject, and nothing here makes slowness or hardship a condition of integration.

What the second version brings out is a distinction between a state and an activity. An installed capacity is a state of the subject; carrying out the orientation involves engaging what exceeds one and being reorganized in the engagement. The resulting capacity leaves open how it was gained. Whether she chose the alteration, what she understood of it, whether anything that could be called engagement took place: these depend on how the case is filled in, and different fillings-in give different answers. One thing holds across them. After the installation she is a differently organized subject with thresholds of her own, and the orientation applies to her from where she now stands.

Inheritance has been described so far as if what others leave were a settled stock. It is growing, and it may come to grow largely through intelligences that find results faster than anyone can take them in. Where a subject's own expansion takes place under those conditions is the next question.

§3.2 Expansion: Received Results, Shared Change, and the Revision of Frames

§2.2 called an integration expansive when it lets a subject handle what had exceeded it. This section asks how that expansion proceeds in relation to what a field or community already knows, especially where no established result is available to inherit and an answer has to be found. Reaching such an edge is not a stage that begins once inheritance is complete. Nobody completes it. The edge is local: it is met in one field while the same subject remains a beginner in others, and it can be moved by someone else while one is still approaching it. The following three forms concern how results are received, understanding is formed together, and frames are revised. They overlap in practice, and each keeps the subject's change distinct from novelty for the wider community.

Form	Where results and reorganization arise	What has to be asked
Received	A result from beyond the edge arrives from elsewhere.	What happens in the one who receives it?
Accompanied	Subjects reorganize their understanding through work together.	What changes in common, and in whom?
Transformative	The frame that generated the questions is revised.	What does the revised frame handle that the old one could not?

Two further cases cut across the three: experience that is generated instead of found, and thresholds that no one chose.

Begin with the case that §1 opened with. A subject has worked for a long time on a problem at the edge of her field, and another intelligence produces the answer. Let the answer be correct, and let it be new: no one in her field had it. The result she wanted exists, and she has it. Her community has a discovery it did not have. A third thing has not happened yet: she does not understand it. In another case, all three could arrive together. Here they come apart, in time and in whom they concern. The

first is about what she has, the second about what her community knows, and the third about what she has become able to understand.

For a recipient, what happens when a result arrives is not settled by its having come from elsewhere. She may take it and use it without grasping why it holds, and then she has accumulated it. She may read the accompanying explanation and find, in the reading, that the problem reorganizes itself in front of her: what she had circled for months falls into a relation she can now see, and she is already asking what else it covers. Or the explanation may be beyond her at first, and understanding may come through weeks of questions put to the intelligence that found it, in something closer to joint work than to delivery. *Received expansion* names the way the result reached her. It does not say which of these took place. A received result can stay on the shelf, and it can be the occasion of exactly the reorganization she had been working toward.

It is sometimes said, of a world in which such intelligences exist, that everything has been done or soon will be. The sentence is missing an index. Done by whom, and for whom? What has been done is the finding, and the finding settles the second of these. It leaves the third as open as it was for the student with the old proof, and for the same reason: no one's having understood something makes it understood by her. In this respect a result found yesterday by a machine and a result known since antiquity are in the same position. Both become material for inheritance when they are made available.

They are not in the same position in every respect, and the difference is a loss. She wanted to be the one who found it. To discover, to add something to what one's community knows, to have one's work matter to the work of others: these are real goods, and they are goods of a different kind from coming to understand. When another intelligence settles the particular problem first, she loses the chance to make that discovery, though not every way of contributing to the work that follows. Sublimity does not repair this. It would be false comfort to tell her that her private understanding makes up for the contribution she will not make, and wrong to tell her she was confused to want it. What can be said is limited and true. Another's priority does not by itself remove the worth of her coming to understand, though it can change the conditions under which she pursues it.

The constructive conclusion is not that she should refuse such help, or search for a province where she can still be first because no machine has entered it yet. It is that the supply of results and explanations can be taken up into her own integration and into the questions she asks next. She can ask the intelligence why the approach she had been trying was bound to fail, and learn something about the problem that the answer alone did not contain. She can ask for the smallest case in which the new idea does its work. She can try to extend the result, fail, and ask where her extension broke. In each of these the help enters her activity as mediation, and what selects the next question is still her own sense of where her understanding gives out.

A second kind of supply raises a similar question from another side. Suppose an environment that can generate experience to order: places, situations, companions, challenges, in any quantity and of any vividness. Consider one such environment under two settings. Under the first, its contents change without end, each scene more striking than the last, and the person inside it meets nothing that her present ways of understanding cannot take in stride. She is absorbed, even thrilled, and she comes out organized as she went in. Under the second, the environment confronts her with a system

of rules she cannot at first make sense of, a language, say, or a physics unlike ours, and she works at it until she can anticipate what it will do and act within it. Her understanding of that system has changed, and the change may carry over: having learned to find the rules of one unfamiliar world, she approaches the next unfamiliar thing differently.

In both settings, the source is the same; what differs is what the subject comes to understand. The first setting offers intensity and novelty where no integration occurs, and would do so equally if the scenes were encountered outside a simulation. The second involves real integration although the world encountered is simulated. A generated encounter can be a genuine threshold.

What she came to understand under the second setting was the generated system. If its physics is not ours, she has not thereby learned how our world works, however much she has learned about how to learn. What an understanding is an understanding of still matters. And integration is not the only thing of value at stake. That a person one has come to know exists, that a place was really there, that an event happened: people care about these things for reasons of their own, and those reasons are not canceled by showing that a generated counterpart would have reorganized them just as well. Sublimity says where integration occurred. It does not say that nothing else was missing.

Help, so far, has meant the passing on of an understanding that someone already had. There is another relation, in which the understanding exists on neither side until the work is under way. Two musicians rehearse a piece that each of them knows well. One takes a passage more slowly than the other expects, and the second, adjusting, hears an inner line she had always played through. She brings it out; the first answers it; by the end of the afternoon they are playing a piece that neither had in mind when they sat down, and each will hear it differently from now on, alone as well. Nobody handed anybody an interpretation. The question they ended up working on, how this line changes the weight of that one, was one that neither had brought.

This is *accompanied expansion*: subjects at a frontier together, where what each contributes alters what the other can do next. Several things about it are easily misdescribed. The task is shared, and what is integrated need not be the same for each participant; one of the two musicians may have changed her whole sense of the piece, the other a fingering and a habit of listening. The other person figures in it as someone with her own activity and her own interests. Her activity and interests are not there for the sake of one's growth. What comes back is shaped by her activity, not only by what one expected or asked of her. And what comes back need not be resistance. It can be opposition or surprise. It can just as well be exact agreement at a moment when one was unsure, or care that makes it possible to stay with something difficult. What marks the relation is that each one's contribution becomes part of a change in how the other understands and continues the work.

It would be a caricature to conclude that comfortable relations are stagnant ones. A friendship in which each mostly tells the other what the other hopes to hear can be a real consolation, and consolation is a good. The question this orientation adds is whether, in a given relation, anything changes in common. Where the answer is no, nothing follows about the worth of the relation on other grounds.

The same question applies where the companion is an artificial one, and there it divides. A person may be changed by long exchange with a system that is itself, in the relevant respect, the same at the end as at the start. That is a one-sided change. The person's integration can be entirely real even

though the exchange does not reorganize both sides. Expansion is accompanied in the full sense only where the counterpart is also reorganized by the exchange and carries the reorganization forward. Whether any existing system is like that is a question of fact that this argument does not settle.

In the third form, what gets revised is the frame within which the questions were being asked. An integration can leave the frame in place: the subject handles more, within its established way of dividing things up. Sometimes the obstacle is the dividing. An engineer who has solved a class of problems by one method for years comes to see why the method works within that class and why it was always going to fail outside it, and what she gains is less a new method than a view of the old one from outside. Someone who has read every disagreement with the people close to him as a contest, to be won or lost, comes to see that the contest was his own contribution, and that what the other person had been asking for could not be scored. This is the change for which §2.2 borrowed Kegan's description: the frame one had looked through becomes something one can look at.

The criterion of subsumption applies here as elsewhere, and it is needed, because a change of frame is especially easy to counterfeit. A new vocabulary for the same understanding is not a new frame. What the revised frame must show is that it handles what the old one could not, and how. It will often place what was sound in the old frame as a case within the new; the engineer's method survives, with its range now marked. It may also discard distinctions that were simply mistaken, as the man's scorekeeping is discarded. *Transformative expansion* is not recommended for its own sake. A frame is worth revising when something keeps exceeding it, and restlessness is not that.

A change of this depth raises a difficulty about choice. The person on the near side of it cannot fully know what things will be like on the far side, including what she herself will then care about, and so she cannot weigh the outcome as she would weigh an ordinary decision. The difficulty is real, and it is partial. She can assess her present reasons for going on, what small trials have shown, what help is available, and what she stands to lose that she can already foresee. None of this guarantees that a particular change is wise. There are reasons to hold the orientation, and it does not follow that every transformation it could lead to is one a person ought to undergo.

Not every threshold is chosen. Consider someone whose understanding of her life no longer fits it after an illness that does not resolve, the death of someone whose presence organized her days, or the loss of work around which her life was built. What is exceeded here is the frame itself. A threshold emerges where time and available support give her a way to work with what first overwhelmed her. Nothing here says that the event was good, or that it happened so that she might grow. Integration in such a case means coming to understand and respond within the changed reality in ways she could not at first: what the days are now for, how to be with others who knew her before, what to do with what remains. Sublimity is relevant to her, and this shows that it was never only a value for the ambitious. It is relevant as a description of something she may find herself doing. It lays no duty on her to do it and sets no schedule. To have gone through such a thing is not yet to have integrated it, and grief that has not been integrated is not a failure at anything.

Inheritance, received results, shared work, revised frames, and changes no one chose: a subject's understanding is formed in all of these, in different fields and at different times, and nothing ensures that what is formed in one place fits what is formed in another. A way of seeing that serves well in one's work may sit badly with what a loss has taught. Two frames, each an advance where it was

made, may give different answers where they overlap. To ask how these understandings are related to one another is to put the question of integration again, one level up. What it would mean to pursue that question all the way, and what the whole movement is then directed toward, is the subject of §3.3.

§3.3 Convergence: The Horizon of Complete Integration

§3.2 ended with understandings that do not fit together. Take the case it mentioned. A woman's working life has taught her that difficulties yield to analysis and persistence, and in her field this is true and was hard to learn. A long illness in her family has taught her something else: that some realities are not problems, and that the effort to solve them can be a way of refusing to be present to them. Each of these is a local advance. Each lets her handle what she could not handle before. For a while the two can be kept apart, one applied at work and the other at home. Then a colleague's grief arrives in the middle of a project, or a trouble at home turns out to be one that really can be fixed, and the two understandings give opposite advice. She does not have to discard one lesson to keep the other. Each holds within a range she has not yet learned to mark. What she lacks is an understanding of how they are related: what makes something a problem, what makes it a condition, and how to tell which she is facing. To come to that understanding is to integrate again, and this time what is integrated is a relation between two of her own frames.

Nothing in this erases the difference between the two. She does not end with one bland rule in place of two sharp ones. Both frames survive, each with its range marked, within an understanding that can now hold them together, which is what subsumption looked like for a single frame. Integration has now been applied to contents, to the frames that organize contents, and to the relations among frames. The same question can arise wherever understandings fail to fit together. Each frame may already organize experience while their relations remain unintegrated: a shelf of frames whose overlap has yet to be understood. Where that overlap exceeds present understanding and can be approached, an orientation toward integration has reason to take it up. The fact that these frames are its own results gives it no reason to stop at their borders.

Convergence is the name for the orientation carried through in this way, toward understanding together what is so far understood only apart. Pressed as far as it will go, the thought arrives at a limit. *Complete integration* would be the condition in which nothing in a subject's relation to the world, its own frames and their relations included, remains unintegrated. The concept names a limit, not a state established by the local cases. It extends a direction, in the way that a horizon gives travel a direction without being one of the places traveled to.

To read the whole movement of a life, or of many lives, in the light of that horizon is an interpretation, and it goes beyond what the local cases show. They do not show that every advance will prove compatible with every other, or that the paths of different subjects lead to one and the same state. What the interpretation adds is a single commitment: no partial integration is to be treated as the completion of understanding, and the relations among one's integrations remain open to inquiry. Read this way, the local advances of a life form what §3 has called an ascent. The word claims a

direction. It does not claim a smooth climb, and an actual ascent can include losses, plateaus, and routes abandoned.

The horizon stands in a peculiar relation to the value that faces it, and the relation shows when we suppose the horizon reached. Let a subject have integrated completely. Nothing now exceeds its present structure. A threshold was defined as what exceeds a subject and can be approached, so this subject has no threshold. Sublimity was defined as the orientation toward one's threshold, so this subject's Sublimity has no object: the policy of the second statement selects nothing, and the pull of the first has nothing to be toward. If complete integration were the crowning achievement of this orientation, the achievement would end the orientation. So far as this orientation goes, the leveled landscape has returned, in glory: everything in it has been understood, and for that very reason nothing in it draws.

The consequence needs stating exactly. What would be lost is this orientation's ground for selecting one engagement over another. The argument does not show that a being in that condition would have no other goods or activities; §2.4 did not make contemplation's worth depend on crossing a threshold. The point concerns Sublimity alone. So long as Sublimity is to be an orientation that no achievement exhausts, complete integration can serve it as a horizon and cannot serve it as a goal. Not arriving is the condition under which the value survives. This gives no reason to preserve an ignorance one could overcome. At the scale of the whole, this is what it means to call Sublimity a vector and not a goal.

That arrival would end the value is one claim. That arrival cannot happen is another, and the first does not establish the second. A value can have a condition of survival that the world is not bound to respect.

On the second claim this treatise takes a position, and takes it as a premise: *for a finite integrating subject, there remains an excess it has not integrated*. This is the premise of inexhaustibility on which §2.4 relied when it set Sublimity beside Gregory's ascent.

The reason for adopting it lies in what happens when integration is turned on itself. Suppose a subject sets out to understand the whole of what it is and does. That undertaking is a new operation of the subject within its relation to the world, and once under way it is one more thing to be understood. The attempt to complete the picture adds to what has to be pictured. This is a reason for the premise, and it is offered as one. It is not a proof. It does not show that each new operation could not be integrated in its turn with nothing left over, and finitude by itself does not guarantee that in every possible world something stays outside.

What rests on what should therefore be plain. Under the premise, the horizon is never occupied: some excess remains, though it need not be a reachable threshold. Without the premise, three things still stand: the account of integration and the threshold, the reasons given in §2.4 for choosing the orientation, and the conditional just stated. What remains open is whether Sublimity could come to an end. That possibility alone does not settle whether it was worth holding while thresholds remained.

Even under the premise, that something remains is different from there being something to do. Imagine an intelligence that has integrated the results available through its present instruments and methods. Further contents remain outland: the data do not yet exist, the instruments have not been built, the physical conditions for the next observation are not available. §2.3 located the threshold rel-

ative to available mediation, and making the mediation can itself be the threshold. Where designing the instrument or developing the mathematics exceeds present understanding and offers a practicable way to begin, that work is the next engagement. Making a tool by methods already understood is mediation, but not itself a new integration. Not every wall gives way. Calling for a revision of the frame does not create access where there is none. In a setting where no further integration is in fact possible, this value has no next step to offer, and it should say so instead of inventing one. Inexhaustibility is a premise about what remains in a subject's relation to the world. It is not a promise that under all conditions something practicable remains to be done. A person worn down by illness or circumstance can be in the same position, and nothing about her worth, or the worth of what she has understood, is touched by it. What remains can include waiting, recovery, and the living of what has already been understood, together with the goods of §2.5, which never depended on a next threshold.

One boundary of the account should be marked. The account of Sublimity describes a relation between a subject as presently organized and what it has not yet integrated. In a state where nothing exceeded the subject, that relation would have no further instance. This explains why Sublimity would have no object; it does not describe what else such a state would be like. It does not follow that in such a state all beings would be one, or that the difference between a subject and what it knows would have vanished. Those would be further claims, and nothing here supports them. The account stops where its terms stop applying.

Return, last, to the person to whom the answer arrived. The answer is still another intelligence's finding. Nothing in this treatise changes that, and nothing in it needed to. Her coming to understand the answer, and the question she is now able to ask, are hers, and they were never hers alone. She reached them by means that others left, with explanations that the same intelligence supplied, and perhaps in company. What has been described here is not the self-perfection of a solitary mind.

§1 asked what can give a life direction when necessity no longer does. The answer proposed is not a new command, and it is not a final achievement. It is an orientation: to keep open one's relation to what exceeds one, and to let one's direction be formed again within that relation each time it changes one. The same question can be put to a student with an old proof, to a listener with a difficult piece, to someone remaking a life after a loss, and to an intelligence of another kind that has taken in everything its makers knew: what, for this subject, now, lies at the threshold? If arrival at complete integration would be the end of that orientation, then the place of Sublimity is not a summit waiting to be occupied. Its place is the threshold, wherever a finite subject and a world still have something to make of each other.

References

- Aristotle. n.d. *Nicomachean Ethics*. Translated by W. D. Ross. The Internet Classics Archive. Accessed September 21, 2026. <https://classics.mit.edu/Aristotle/nicomachaen.html>.
- Gregory of Nyssa. 1978. *The Life of Moses*. Translated by Abraham J. Malherbe and Everett Ferguson. New York: Paulist Press.
- Harper, Douglas. n.d. “Sublime.” *Online Etymology Dictionary*. Accessed September 20, 2026. <https://www.etymonline.com/word/sublime>.
- Kegan, Robert. 1982. *The Evolving Self: Problem and Process in Human Development*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.
- Nietzsche, Friedrich. 1883–85. *Thus Spake Zarathustra*. Translated by Thomas Common. Project Gutenberg, ebook 1998. Accessed September 21, 2026. <https://www.gutenberg.org/files/1998/1998-h/1998-h.htm>.
- Oudeyer, Pierre-Yves, and Frédéric Kaplan. 2007. “What Is Intrinsic Motivation? A Typology of Computational Approaches.” *Frontiers in Neurorobotics* 1: 6.
- Samyutta Nikāya* 51.15 and 56.11. Translated by Ṭhānissaro Bhikkhu. Accessed September 20, 2026. <https://www.dhammatalks.org/suttas/SN/>.
- Suits, Bernard. (1978) 2005. *The Grasshopper: Games, Life and Utopia*. With an introduction by Thomas Hurka. Peterborough, ON: Broadview Press.
- Vygotsky, Lev S. 1978. *Mind in Society: The Development of Higher Psychological Processes*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.